



A GUIDE FOR BUSINESS OWNERS
FROM TRUE HAVEN PRESS

The Authority Asset

*A practical white paper for business owners who want to
turn a manuscript into a credible authority asset,
a strong lead magnet, and a measurable growth tool.*



You've Done the Hard Part

Most business owners who intend to write a book never make it past the idea stage. The concept lingers on a someday list, crowded out by more immediate demands. You moved beyond that. You finished the manuscript, which places you at the edge of a more commercially important decision.

A finished manuscript is not yet a finished business asset. The publishing decisions that follow determine whether what you wrote becomes a high-trust tool that supports growth or a file that never meaningfully enters your sales process.

It is a real decision, and an expensive one to get wrong. Publish it cheaply and badly, and you'll have a book you are slightly reluctant to hand to a prospect. Publish it with no thought to positioning or distribution, and you'll have a book no one beyond your existing network ever sees. Choose the wrong partner, and you'll spend real money but still end up with something that does nothing for your business.

This guide is designed to help you evaluate that decision clearly and efficiently. It is intentionally concise, because your time matters and because once the tradeoffs are visible, the right next step usually becomes much easier to see.

What “Publishing It Right” Means for a Business Book

Before comparing publishing paths, define success correctly. For a business book, success is rarely about copies sold. It is about business impact.

A novel is judged by sales. A business book usually is not, and should not be. You might sell ten thousand copies or give a thousand away at conferences, and either way, the question that matters is what the book does for your business. A business book earns its keep through:

- **Authority.** It has to be a credible introduction to you, your business, and what problem(s) you can solve or product(s) you can provide for your target market. A prospect who reads your book arrives already convinced you are the subject matter expert.
- **Lead generation.** The book leverages calls to action and a funnel system that draws in the right people and starts the relationship for you.

- **Shorter sales cycles.** Prospects arrive in your sales channel pre-sold, having already spent hours with your thinking, so the conversation starts much further along.
- **Door opener.** Speaking invitations, podcasts, media, partnerships. A book is a key to rooms that are otherwise hard to enter.

In practical terms, “publishing it right” means producing and positioning the book so it consistently drives those outcomes. That requires four things:

- **Professional quality,** because the book represents your brand and a cheap-looking book quietly undercuts the very authority it is meant to build.
- **Sharp positioning,** so the book speaks directly to the clients you want.
- **Genuine distribution,** so it reaches beyond the people who already know you.
- **Sensible timeline,** so the asset is working for your business this year, not eventually.

Hold those four—quality, positioning, distribution, timeline—as your standard while weighing your options.

03 THE LANDSCAPE

Your Options, and What Each One Costs You

There are three realistic publishing paths for most business owners. Each offers a different mix of speed, control, expertise, ownership, and effort.

Traditional publishing. You pay the editing costs, then a publisher pays the design costs and handles production, and in return takes the rights to your book and pays you a royalty of roughly 10 to 15 percent. It is highly selective, slow—frequently a year or two from deal to shelf—and leaves you little control over the cover, the title, or the timing. For a business owner, there is a deeper problem: a traditionally published book is, in an important sense, the publisher’s asset, not yours. For a book whose entire purpose is to serve your business, that is the wrong arrangement even when it is available, which for most business books it is not.

Self-publishing. You keep complete control and every right, and you move as fast as you can manage. But you also become the publisher, having to invest your time in hiring and coordinating the editors, cover designer, and interior designer, then learning how to publish through navigating a lot of online resources and ultimately learning by trial and error what works and doesn’t work. You own every quality decision and every mistake. Done with skill and good people and a big time investment from you, this

method can produce an excellent book. Done without, it produces exactly the cheap-looking book that costs you authority and doesn't drive leads, and you rarely know which you have until it's all said and done.

Hybrid publishing. You invest in the production of the book, and in return you get a professionally produced result, a managed process, and an experienced partner while keeping your rights and your royalties. It is the path that most directly answers what a business owner actually wants: professional quality, real speed, retained ownership, and guidance without having to learn how to publish books. It's like hiring a team of experts who will get your input and your final approval every step of the way.

04 HOW TO WEIGH COST

The Investment Lens

Cost is usually the first question business owners ask, which is understandable, but on its own, it is not the most useful lens.

The better question is not, "What is the cheapest way to get this printed?" It is, "What kind of asset am I creating, and what will it return if it is done well?" Low-cost publishing that yields a weak book, poor positioning, or ineffective retail presence is not efficiency. It is underperforming spend.

The right approach is to analyze the potential return on investment like you would with any other business investment: What will this return, and what's it worth to get it right? So do the arithmetic you already know how to do.

- ? What is one new client worth to you over the life of the relationship? For many professional businesses, the answer is thousands, sometimes far more.
- ? Against that number, how many clients will a professionally published, well-positioned book need to bring in to return its cost? For most business owners that number is small, and the book can clear it comfortably and quickly.
- ? How many clients would the investment bring to your business year after year? What does that company growth and increased profit margin look like over the long term?

This is also why a credible publisher will not quote you a flat price from a list. The right investment depends on the book—its length and condition, what it needs editorially, the formats your clients will want, and what you are trying to achieve with it. A serious publisher assesses the manuscript and understands your goals first, and only then gives you a clear, complete quote custom built for your project. A number offered before anyone has read your book is not transparency—it is usually a sales tactic focused on revenue first, quality second, and long-term success not at all.

Choosing a Publishing Partner Who Gets It

If you decide to publish your book as a serious business asset, partner selection becomes a strategic decision. The right publishing partner should improve quality, reduce friction, and strengthen the business outcome—not simply move files through production.

GREEN FLAGS — WHAT TO LOOK FOR

- ✓ **Production quality you can see.** Ask to look at other business lead magnet books they have published.
- ✓ **You keep your rights and your royalties.** The book remains your business asset, living in your accounts where you have full control of receiving payments directly, zero delays in reporting, and can make changes without waiting on someone else over the long term.
- ✓ **They treat your book as a business asset.** They ask what you want the book to do for your business, not only what it is about, and then assesses the manuscript and shares those results to customize the editing plan and overall pricing. A partner who understands the job can help the book do it, and proper assessment allows for custom, transparent pricing.
- ✓ **Realistic timelines.** A sensible schedule and honesty about what is and is not possible and where/how you and the publisher each affect the timeline.

RED FLAGS — WARNING SIGNS

- ! **Vague or shifting pricing.** They will not put numbers in writing. The price shifts between conversations. Fees appear that were never mentioned.
- ! **Pressure and urgency.** “This rate is only good this week.” A real investment decision is not made on someone else’s deadline.
- ! **One-size-fits-all packages.** Bundles that discount pricing use cheap, unskilled labor or AI.
- ! **Guarantees of success.** Promises of bestseller status, specific sales figures, or your book on shelves in stores nationwide. No one can guarantee sales, and note the difference between a book being available to stores and being stocked by them. The first is normal while the second is something no publisher controls.

- ! **No selectivity.** Your manuscript is accepted within hours, with no real evaluation. Flattery is not assessment.
- ! **Rights grabs.** Contract language that takes your copyright, or ties up your rights for a long term with no clear way to get them back.
- ! **A hollow track record.** Few books, weak cover design, no authors you can find online, or glowing testimonials with no verifiable source.
- ! **“Everything included” but nothing itemized.** Be wary of packages that sound comprehensive but never specify what you actually receive.

The principle is simple: a good partner welcomes your scrutiny, and a publishing decision—even a fast-moving business one—is yours to make carefully.

The Next Step

At this point, the question is no longer whether your manuscript has value. It does. The question is how to publish it in a way that aligns with your goals, your timeline, and the role you want the book to play inside your business.

We created this guide to help business owners make that decision from a position of clarity rather than pressure. In some cases, the right move is to publish now. In others, it may be to refine the manuscript, improve positioning, or choose a different path entirely.

If you want a clear picture of what publishing your book well would require, the next step is simple: bring us your finished manuscript and your business goals. We will assess the manuscript, identify what it needs, discuss what you want the book to do for your business, and outline what a professionally published, commercially useful version of the book would look like. If we are not the right fit, we will tell you plainly so you can move forward with better information and a stronger plan.

See what your book could become.

Bring your questions, your manuscript, and your goals, and we'll show you what a professionally published, authority-building version of your book would look like.

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Transparent ~ Reliable ~ Unwavering ~ Excellence

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